Volume 4 Issue 1 Summer 2010

Hollerbeier Haven

Living Deitsch Wisdom in the 21st Century

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Die Volkstimme

Losset uns die Welt mit Glaarheet aagucke.

Losset uns darrich en neii Linse sehne.

Losset uns zamme mit Weesheet im Hatz schteh.

Un darrich daer verlegget Daag zu der Lilyezeit geh.

Let us see the world with clarity.

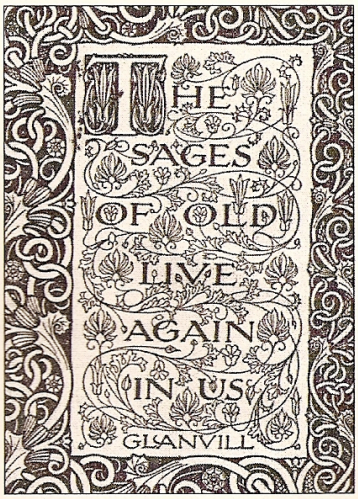
Let us look through a new lens.

Let us stand together with Wisdom in our hearts.

And pass through this troubled day to the time of the Lilly.

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The Three Sisters Center for the Healing Arts is recording stories, interviews, memories, and knowledge of the healing traditions of Pow-wow or Braucherei. We are creating an archive of this tradition in order to preserve our heritage and ensure the practice. If you know anyone who practices or has a story to tell, we'd love to hear from you; whether you'd like to give a personal interview or prefer to remain anonymous, simply write to us. Your personal experiences are culturally valuable and will be treated with the utmost respect. You can contact us with questions or information by writing to:

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Dear Readers,

The joy of the advent of summer this year is marred by the deep tragedy we are facing as a global community. The massive oil spill that began on April 20th of this year is an unprecedented catastrophe. As I am writing, the well has still not been sealed, and it seems unlikely to be sealed anytime soon. Anytime it is sealed is not soon enough.

With this issue I am bringing into focus the importance of the transformation of our ways as a people as we move into the future. There is no room for this sort of wasteful and devastating accident in our already polluted world. I pray that this accident will bring people together, unite those who would not have worked in tandem before. I pray that we might put aside our differences and work to solve our problems. Democrat, Republican, Libertarian, Green, these differences seem so trivial in the light of the changes we must make. Regardless of color or creed we must all breathe the same air, drink the same water, eat from the same bounty of the earth.

I pray that we learn from the example of the traditional Deitsch way of life. No Deitsch farmer would have fouled his soil, his water. He would have taken great care with the resources he acted as steward over. He would have acted as though his life and the lives of all his children depended on this, his dedication to the loving stewardship of the earth that he was given custody of for his brief stay on it.

Blessings
Jesse Tobin, Editor
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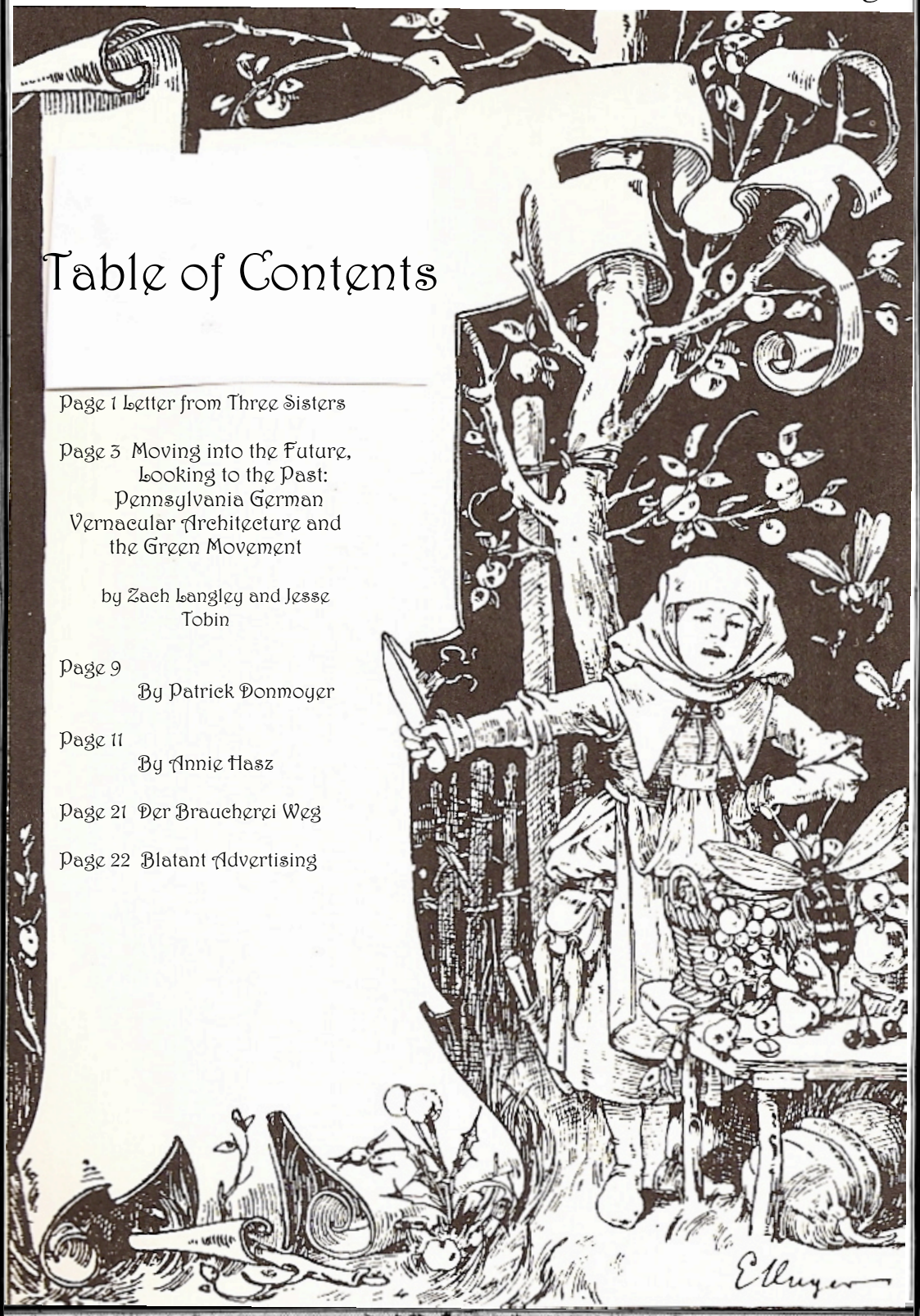


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Moving into the Future, Looking to the Past:

Pennsylvania German Vernacular Architecture and the Green Movement
by Zach Langley and Jesse Tobin



Pictured above is the Blue Rocks Home: the house that Matthew and Jesse (and family and friends built over the course of the last year and a half.

In the early 18th century, much of European life remained locked in the middle ages. Dukes and lords ruled over serf farmers that populated their estates and farmed their fields for them, often forcing the serfs to pay for their houses with taxes levied on the crops they grew. During this time, a mass wave of immigrants began fleeing the German Palatinate region and the impoverished lives of serfs for the assumed riches of the New World. They mostly arrived in the port city of Philadelphia with a few measly possessions that had survived the journey. They also brought something else contained within their minds- a folk culture that flourished into the Pennsylvania German, or Dutch, culture of south-eastern and central Pennsylvania and that continued from generation to generation for almost 200 years. The Pennsyfaanish Deitsch people have endured several waves of assimilation and dissolution of their culture over their 300 years in America. Many aspects of the culture have suffered or disappeared entirely. One legacy endures beyond all others, h**o**wever: take a drive down any back road in any of the counties were these immigrants first settled and you will find the treasure trove that cultural assimilation cannot destroy: architecture.

Throughout the first 100 years of their tenure in Pennsylvania,

Pennsylvania Germans set themselves apart visually with their own culturally-based architectural designs, as well as a variety of folk arts. Such design was more than just style and whim. The entire culture was focused on farm life: from the first stone of the foundation to the layout of fields, crop rotation, and even spiritual life. All elements of the PA Deitsch worldview orbited around the family farm. It was this reality that defined the Pennsylvania Dutch folk culture for centuries.

This is as much true in the design and construction of traditional farmsteads, as it is in any other area. The modern home has become a pieced together shell of cheap pine lumber, drywall, vinyl siding, and plywood. In contrast, to 18th century Pennsylvania Germans the home was more than just a place to store possessions or entertain friends. It was the basis for all life and great care and pride was taken in the home: its style, design, and in many cases its decoration. To many the old stone homes of that 18th and 19th centuries may seem just a quaint reminder of times gone by. In stark contrast to this notion, we believe that the design, construction and farming techniques developed by the PA Deitsch hold significant relevance for green builders and homeowners of the 21st century.

The popularity of today's green movement and the environmental conscience that goes with it, help make these homes, buildings, and practices more than mere novel reminders of days gone by. The materials, design theories, and farming practices of the Pennsylvania Dutch are easily adapted to application in modern eco-conscious construction. Such a rethinking of the architectural and farming practices of the Pennsylvania Germans reveals that many of these seemingly obsolete practices and materials remain viable. In some cases the archaic materials and techniques are even superior environmental choices. Through this understanding the architecture and farming culture of the Pennsylvania German can continue to enrich the lives of modern builders and remodelers, hobby farmers, and the environmentally conscious.

In this article we will describe traditional materials and designs along with potential modern applications. As most of you know, Jesse has been involved in a self-built home project with her husband, Matthew Sicher and their crew of friends and family for well over a year. As this project (called here "the Blue Rocks Home") draws to a close, we will use examples and lessons from this project specifically. Historical examples are made by Zach from Deitsch farms and museums local to Southeastern PA.

Materials

To understand the relevancy of historic architecture, we must examine the building blocks of the home. If we are to appreciate the homes of Pennsylvania Germans then we must understand the materials that make up the guts of the structure. An examination of these materials will reveal that in many cases the historic options are actually superior to what is today used to perform the same task. Many reveal themselves as more ecologically friendly. For example, many older building materials possess higher natural R insulation values, are locally abundant, or lend themselves easily to salvaging for reuse in modern homes. All these traits are desirable to the environmentally conscious builder.

Wood

Wood is the most essential of traditional building materials. Its use predated the use of stone or brick in colonial German application, and its use is of continuing importance. Amos Long points out in his book, *The Pennsylvania German Family Farm*, the Pennsylvania German "invariably selected land which was heavily timbered with hardwoods". To the new settler such wood indicated excellent soil and a ready source with which to build the home and farmstead. In early log homes,

few of which survive, this meant enough wood to build the entire exterior structure. In newer stone homes this meant flooring, framing, and even walls to fill in the interior of the stone walls. Wood became essential to the assessment of the home. As historian Cynthia Falk points out, Philadelphian doctor Benjamin Rush once described the economic status of Pennsylvania German settlers based on whether settlers lived in log or stone homes and what types of logs a settler used to build his dwelling: the rougher and cruder the home, the poorer the owner.

On travels with our friend and barn historian, Patrick Donmoyer, we have come to find oak, poplar, chestnut, and yellow pine as common types of wood found in many Pennsylvania Dutch structures. These are all (with the exception of Chestnut of course) woods that are still plentiful in the Pennsylvania countryside, lending themselves well to the bioregional builder.

To the modern remodeler, wood does present itself as a difficult form of material to use in an environmentally friendly way. Although wood is technically a renewable resource, it has been vastly over-harvested in many parts of the United States. There are, however, a few options available to the conscious builder.

In the case of new construction on a wooded lot, a builder can choose to hire a wood miser to come and create the lumber needed from the trees that take up what will be the footprint of the homestead. Another option is to purchase local wood from a local sawmill and sell lumber from your house site back to them. In the construction of the Blue Rocks Home we opted for the latter, as there were no wood misers willing to come up our 1/4 mile driveway for the limited amounts of wood we had for milling.

Another large benefit of wood is its ability to be easily salvaged. Many hardwoods may appear faded and weathered on the outside, but a little time planing and sanding will often reveal fresh beautiful wood under the surface which can be utilized for a variety of functions. One can compare this to today's modern white pine often used to build a house. One is challenged to find a board in any modern home improvement store that is not warped, cracked, or so full of knots as to be almost useless. With the amount of historic buildings being torn down today, there is also a ready supply of salvaged historic hardwood and in fact an entire industry has grown up around salvaged siding and flooring. Upon visiting an architectural salvage yard in Orefield, Pennsylvania, this point was made plain by piles of salvaged wood over fifteen feet high, and occupying the better part of an acre of property. Often times old structural timbers from large factory buildings of the 19th century can be milled into beautiful floors, siding, wainscoting, etc. Finally, the first growth hard wood of 200 years ago is often more rot resistant than today's commercial white pine, extending the life for whatever purpose it is put to.

Stone

While wood may have been the foundation of historic interiors it is stone that was the most popular form of exterior building material until the Victorian era. Amos Long states that it was only a natural progression for Pennsylvania Germans to look for more durable materials than logs to build their homes from and for many settlers this meant utilizing the mass deposits of limestone in the area, whether it be turned up field stones or cut quarried stone. A survey of many of the historic Pennsylvania Dutch houses now open as museums speaks to the popularity of stone as a building material. In the main Pennsylvania German settlement regions there are almost 50 publicly accessible stone house museums from the 18th century that I can think of off the top of my head. These include such homes as the Hans Herr house in Lancaster, the Troxell-Steckell house near Allentown, the Hottenstein

Mansion of Berks County, and the Peter Wentz farmstead in Montgomery County, just to name a few.

Just like wood, stone also lends itself to a more environmentally conscious method of building. This is first and foremost because it is a local resource to this area of Pennsylvania and thus does not require the waste of fossil fuels in shipping. In addition to this, the R value of limestone, lends it an additional green hue. R value is determined by an algebraic equation that measures the insulating abilities of a material, the higher the number the better the insulating abilities of a material. According to the Marble Institute of America, limestone possesses an R value of .114 per inch thickness. In a foot thick stone wall that equates out to 1.368. This compares to the 1.28 R value per foot of concrete block.

Although these numbers may not be drastically different, one must remember that in most historic homes the walls are much thicker than one foot. The quaint deep window sills that many people think of in historic homes are there for more than just looks- the walls are actually that thick. Stone also lends itself well to salvaging and a trip to any architectural salvage yard will reveal that stone most likely occupies a portion of the space at least equal to that of wood. In addition to salvaging opportunities, new stone is a very strong presence in much of the Pennsylvania countryside, with new stone being turned up at every plowing. In the simple act of excavation for a new home, huge amounts of stone can be turned up and used in the building process.

Additionally, stone is almost indestructible except in the case of weather erosion. Look at any stone home and the stones are most likely original to the building of a house, this can be compared to vinyl siding which often is rated to lasted only twenty-five to fifty years. The fact that any old siding removed during new installation cannot be recycled and is essentially non-biodegradable only adds to the environmentally unfriendly nature of vinyl siding. In our opinion, vinyl siding and Asphalt roofs are what is wrong with the modern building industry. The waste is enormous, toxicity is present not only in the production and disposal of the materials, but also as it off-gasses during the entirety of its life on the home!

Brick and Clay

Brick became popular as a secondary building material after the end of the 18th century. Bricks were also one of the most common secondary building items used for outbuildings and other structures among the Deitsch during the first three centuries of settlement in Pennsylvania. Amos Long points out that in the 19th century brick houses rivaled stone for the preferred home building material. By the Victorian Era (the latter part of the 19th century), the popularity of brick had surpassed that of stone altogether.

Although brick may not have become popular as a dominant building material until the mid-19th century (by which time most Pennsylvania German vernacular architecture had long been replaced by American styles), its importance to the 18th century Deitsch farmstead cannot be denied. Outbuildings such as the root cellars, bake ovens, and smokehouses were just as vital to farm life as were homes. Such buildings made survival possible by allowing preparation and storage for food, a necessity to survival in subsistence farm communities. Long also suggests that bricks were easy to build with because most of the material was able to be found on the farm. A perusal through Long's book shows how popular brick was in the construction of outbuildings.

The clay used for making brick was also important for many other tasks and structures throughout the history of the Pennsylvania Germans settlers. In many early log homes local clay deposits formed

the basis for the daub mixture used in construction. The overlapping logs which formed the exterior walls of these homes, left air spaces between the actual logs which needed to be filled. During construction scrap pieces of wood were laid diagonally within the spaces and a mixture of clay, lime dust, hair or straw, and water was used to fill in the gaps, allowing for drainage when logs expanded and contracted and adding to the insulation of the home.

Brick and clay also present a very green alternative to modern building materials. The clay composition of bricks presents a renewable resource that can be easily mixed with minimal work. Unlike, modern forms of block used in construction, it is still quite possible to make bricks from scratch with a little time, energy, clay and water. Brick also exhibits a high R value of .80 per 4 inch thick brick. That equates to 2.4 per foot which presents a far better choice when compared to limestone's 1.368 per foot. Clay, when used by itself, does even better as it retains an R factor of 2.00 per inch of thickness. Thus, bricks and clay, while not as popular in Pennsylvania German building as limestone, should be considered as a prime material in areas where a higher insularly factor is desired.

The value of masonry elements of a home goes far beyond R value. These masonry components could be considered to be temperature batteries. This is more an issue of design, but part of design is choosing materials! All masonry retains heat and cold longer than wood, or most other building materials. When used appropriately in design this can mean a built in air-conditioner or heater. In green building this type of material used in a home is called "thermal mass" . The central aspect of the masonry is its density. This density means that it takes a long time to heat or cool a large piece of masonry. Once this masonry has been heated or cooled, however, it takes relatively little energy to maintain that temperature, particularly if the thermal mass is well insulated. One thing we have going for us in modern construction is that we can insulate very very well! The only difficulty is that in order to glean the climate-control benefits of masonry, the insulation has to be on the outside of the masonry. This presents only one problem: how to insulate outside the masonry and do so in a graceful and aesthetically pleasing way? We will speak more on this further on in this article.

Sheathing

The next building block, we will examine is not a material but a feature- the roof. Pennsylvania German homes were covered with a variety of different materials. Early homes featured what has become known as long shingles. This shingle design was a Pennsylvania development where 3 foot long shingles were used to give extra overlap to rows of shingles, in addition to this overlap in length, these shingles also utilized a side lap. This allowed two of the three exposed sides of shingle to be overlapped by another shingle. This shingle was made of similar hardwoods used in the framing of the house such as oak.

Later homes began to use slate or clay tile shingles which continued to be used until well into the 20th century. To support the extra weight of masonry roofs, the Pennsylvania Dutch utilized an Old World roof truss system called the *Liegander Dachstuhl* which featured an extra support system shaped like a reclined chair.

Some outbuildings, especially the hay barrack, utilized thatch roofing to some extent, though thatching was not nearly as often used among the Deitsch as it was by other groups of settlers. The primary material for this method was rye straw which farmers grew as a grain crop for making bread. Straw was then lashed to the roof lathe providing a simple, removable, renewable roofing system.

These materials just like other Pennsylvania German building materials also possess features that are environmentally respectful. The most

obvious benefit should be the insulation provided by thatch roofing, the most insulating material used by the Pennsylvania Dutch. According to McGhee & Co. Roofers, an artisan thatching company based in Virginia, a 12 inch thick roof of thatch possesses an R value of 40, higher than some common fiberglass insulations. The R value of a typical asphalt roof is .44 per inch and this low number is only amplified when the fact is revealed that a typical asphalt roof is only an inch thick or so. Not nearly as cozy as thatch, wood shingles do, however, still win out over asphalt with an R value of .97, more than double that of asphalt. Both wood and thatch are also choice materials due to their biodegradability. Adding to this, the Transportation Research Board, a nonprofit research group, points out that:

> "U.S. roofing manufacturers produce more than one million tons of new waste roofing shingles (not meeting specifications) and shingle trimmings. Additionally, residential and commercial roofing replacement activities generate another 10 million tons of old roofing waste. Historically, about 95% of this 22 million cubic yards of valuable, non-biodegradable solid waste has been placed in landfills."

Most of the material used in this waste is not biodegradable and as such simply sits in landfills. The major issue facing the use of materials such as thatch is building codes. This issue with code goes far beyond the border of Pennsylvania, and most of the United States. Most of the US has adopted the universal building codes which prohibit the use of thatch roofing due to its flammability. In fact, even places such as the UK and Ireland, whose beautiful thatched roofs are world renowned, often prohibit the construction of new thatch roofs for the same reasons, namely flammability.

We are under the impression that wood shingles are still allowed, though that is not verified. So, other than wood, what roofing materials can be used that are ecologically responsible? There are a few options here, though some are rather expensive and thus less likely to be used.

Slate is, of course, a beautiful and long lasting roofing material. Unfortunately the cost of a new slate roof is completely cost prohibitive. Another option is to collect slates as old slate roofs are torn down and use the scavenged slates on a new roof. The advantage and disadvantage to this is that the slates will most likely be of mixed sizes and shapes. To the artful mind this is an opportunity to make a beautiful design. To the linear mind this is nothing more than a pain in the butt! These same scavenged slates can be used, much as wood shingles often are: as siding. The use of slate shingles as siding would present a type of siding that would most certainly outlast the life of the builder! As siding, the slate would have even less wear and tear due to sun and weather, and barring breakage these slates could last for hundreds of years. This type of siding is used often to cover old European German half-timbered structures, allowing for little to no maintenance on the exterior of these historic buildings.

In the Blue Rocks Home we planned to use slate as the primary siding material. Due to time pressures, however, we decided to use cedar clapboard. In this we traded a much needed tax credit for a lot more maintenance! We do plan to use the scavenged slate we collected in some areas of the house. We will cover the cedar in some places with slate (namely the gable ends at their peak) this will be done in areas where maintaining the cedar is more difficult. In other places we will cover the rough scratch coat on the exterior of the masonry walls with slate. The majority of the slate will be incorporated into the

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Hagal – The Holy Hail

by Patrick Donmoyer

"Hail is the whitest of grain,
It sweeps from the sky,
Is whirled by the wind,
And turns into water."

-Anglo Saxon Rune Poem, Thomas Howard Translation

The ninth rune is Hagal, which is literally the ancient Germanic word for hail. It's form is similar to the Latin letter H, except that the crossmember joining the two vertical staves is a diagonal rather than a horizontal line. In later adaptations of the runic alphabet used by the Scandinavians, Hagal takes the form of a six-spoked wheel or star. This particular pattern is produced by three staves crossing, creating six equal intervals of 60 degrees. This later form is identical in every respect to the six-pointed compass star or rosette which saturates Pennsylvania German folk art and architecture. This geometric arrangement is incredibly significant to the ancient and modern word, both mathematically, as the basis for Euclidean geometry, and religiously, as a symbol of the passage of time and resurrection.

Hagal has been occasionally referred to as a Mother Rune, as its geometry allows for all other runes to be formed from the angles of its three intersecting staves. Its stable, regular form is an echo of the crystallization of quartzite, and the complexity of a snow flake. The significance of Hagal's relation to the observation of nature cannot be understated. Because of this conceptualization, Hagal represents the inherent rhythm and regularity of the cosmos. According to Norse and Germanic mythology, all of material existence is ultimately derived from the co-mingling of primordial heat and cold. For the ancients, both of these conditions form the necessary tension to bring the world into existence and to perpetuate and sustain it. The three staves can be understood as a triplicity, formed from the conjunction of two, producing the third. While the 7th rune Gifu represents a partnership of two complementary forces, Hagal is a communion of opposing essences, which generates a third condition, which can be understood as change. Interestingly enough, the emphasis on creation as a primary interpretation of the Hagal rune is mirrored in the Judaic Star of David, which symbolizes the six days of creation, radiating about a central hexagon, symbolizing a static day in which the divine creative force rested upon completion. The Star of David can likewise be reduced to two ancient astrological and alchemical symbols for fire and water, with the upright and inverted equilateral triangles.

The element of triplicity is especially important to the mythological associations of Hagal. The three Norns, or the wyrd sisters, comparable to the Greco-Roman Fates, personify the numerical metaphor of the mythological triplicity, by representing human experience as a function of three expressions of time in the past, present and future. The Three Sisters were beings responsible for maintaining the balance of the fabric of time, and they were all depicted as diligent textile artisans. One sister spun the fiber of existence into thread, while another wove it into fabric, and the third would disassemble the fabric.



A balance, of creation, patterning and destruction characterizes the triplicity of Hagal. A hailstone is a sudden, dangerous addition to a thunderstorm, bringing with it both destruction, protection, and potential for new growth as the water melts.

The significance of Hagal is ever-present in Pennsylvania German culture, and yet it is nearly, but not-quite yet, invisible. According to folklorist Edwin Miller Fogel who wrote in the 1920's, the first hailstones of the year were both lucky and protective to the Pennsylvania Germans. Fogel attributed many Deitsch beliefs as proceeding from ancient folkways associated with the reverence for the Thunder god Thor, or Dunnar in Pennsylvaanisch Deitsch. Just as the expression "*Dunnarwedder!"* is still used to this day as an expletive, many folks continue to believe that it merely means "Thunderstorm," even when other more meteorological-specific terms such as *Gewidder* are more commonly used instead for the actual, non-metaphorical weather conditions. In fact, "Dunnarwedder" is often combined with a long string of other ancient invocations which over many generations have been reduced to proverbial curse words. Strings of such expletives, such as *Himmel-Haagel-Schtaern Dunnerwetter!* and *Kreuz-Haagel Schtaern Dunnerwetter!*, meaning literally, "Holy Hail Star Dunnar Weather," and "Hail-Cross Star Dunnar Weather" which have been collected by folkloric authors such as Don Yoder and Leonard Schupp, indicate a more complex, nearly forgotten relationship between the ancestral beliefs of the significance of the "Hail-Star" and mythological tradition. This Hailstar could be none other than the ubiquitous six-pointed rosette illustrated motif which graces the siding of Pennsylvania barns, keystones and gravestones of protestant churches, and countless other applications in Pennsylvania German Material Culture. It is still debated to this day whether the rosette continued to hold its magical connotation into the 19th and 20th centuries. There remains to this day ample evidence enough to make this debate exceedingly interesting.

The significance of the Hagal rune in divination is complex. Finding this rune in a reading requires the querent to remember the passage of time and to observe the patterns of nature which repeat in every aspect of life. Hagal, just like Gifu, has no inverted meaning. In remembering that one's life is a reflection of every other progression which unfolds in nature, one can begin to understand that although life may appear chaotic, sudden, and dangerous, like an impending hailstorm, all aspects of experience are a part of a greater context of universality. Opposing forces are not merely a dualistic conception, but a potential for the creation of a third option. When this relationship is significantly internalized, fear, doubt and insecurity can be transformed into decisive action, responsibility, and motivation at the mere drop of a hailstone.

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Tongue Tales

by Jesse Tobin

Tongue seems to me to be about the tamest of the marginal meats. That is why I was surprised when my attempt to feed it to my loved ones was met with sour looks and abrupt changes in plans (namely to eat dinner out!). On several occasions I offered to cook up a tasty tongue dish (hoping for many taste testers) and found myself down to only two: Matthew and myself. Finally I forced it on the Three Sisters Circle at one of our seasonal gatherings. They tried it. They loved it!

Tongue is a very rich meat. It is not a richness that comes from fat, either. The tongue is a thick and powerful muscle, and it can end up rather tough if it is not cooked properly. I had a host of lamb's tongues to create this dish with. The one thing I will say about tongue is this: the bigger the better. There is so much prep involved with each bit of meat that it is best to maximize your laborious efforts.

In order to prepare tongue for cooking, you must first cook it in boiling water for quite a while. In searching through recipes the shortest amount of time I found was 15 minutes for this first phase of cooking. The longest was 3 hours. The point here is to tenderize this otherwise tough bit of meat. After the initial boiling, the tough outer skin of the tongue is peeled away to reveal a now tender inner core. There is also some gristle and bone near the end of the tongue (the point at which it was attached) that needs to be cut off and cleaned up.

Once the initial clean up and prep is done, I find it best to slice the tongue into smaller pieces. For some reason it is hard for a lot of folks to bite into a piece of meat that is tongue-shaped. I find that slicing it up makes more people willing to take that first bite. Below is the recipe I tried out on my friends and family:

6 prepared lamb's tongues (boiled, peeled, and cleaned)
butter
1 onion
1 bag baby spinach
1 cup white wine
tarragon, salt, and pepper to taste

Chop the onion and set it to saute in a saucepan. Slice the tongues into thin slices. When onions have cooked clear, add the tongue and baby spinach. Saute lightly. After about 5 minutes, add the white wine and spices and turn the stove down to simmer. When liquid is almost gone, remove from heat and serve. This dish pairs well with mashed potatoes or parsnips.

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Urglaawischi Gemietlichkeet

By Rob Lusch

Virtually every language has words that are difficult, if not impossible, to translate into a different language, which is why words are often adopted from one language into another. Some words reflect concrete items, such as insects that are native to a particular area or a legal process that is unique to a given country. Other words reflect concepts that are new or are unique to a given culture, such as the Polynesian system of *tapu* or *kapu* becoming (with some revision) known as *taboo* in English.

One Deitsch word that does not translate exactly into English is *Gemietlichkeet* (or *Gemietlichkeit*, depending on one's local variant of the language). This word is frequently translated as coziness, and that translation is certainly valid. However, there is a deeper aspect to the word that warrants more explanation.

Gemietlichkeet is also a state of belonging to everything and having everything belong to us. It is also a soul-satisfying joy or happiness that simultaneously emanates from and includes that state of belonging. Urglaawe philosophy holds that Gemietlichkeet is a primary goal for personal and community achievement.

A lack of a sense of belonging permeates much of our society in the current era. Very real circumstances force our attention to be focused on paying bills, finishing school projects, ensuring that our jobs skills are current (if we are lucky enough even to have a job!), worrying about the wars or politics, or any number of other issues that constantly bombard us. Many of us barely know our neighbors or are unable to spend a significant amount of time with loved ones. This disconnection from home, family, and community has led to numerous social problems about which all of us are most certainly already painfully aware.

Outside of taking prescription medications, what can be done about this situation? One seemingly simple answer comes to Urglaawe via Braucherei: attune your mindset with the time of year. Right now we are between Walpurgisnacht (April 30) and Midsummer (June 21). At this time we are encouraged to revel in the joys of life. Celebrate the warmth of the sun on the land, the growth of the flowers or the crops, and the love of friends, family and Sippschaft. These are the wonders of life, and through deliberate, conscious living and embracing these joys we begin to set the foundations for incorporating a sense of Gemietlichkeet into our daily routines.

In the next issue we will explore this concept deeper, including dealing with challenges that we commonly face. In the mean time, I invite everyone to consider all the reasons to be grateful for the people and the things we have around us! Hail!

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Continued from page 8.....

summer kitchen..... which will not be built this year!

Another roofing option is clay tile. Clay roofs are used often in the southwest US and also quite often in Europe. As you might expect this material has some similarity with Slate, namely its weight! Along with slate, clay roofs also have a place among the historic farms of the Deitsch. There are some differences, however. Clay tiles are more affordable than slate, though they are still not as cheap as asphalt. It is plausible, however, that clay tiles, like brick, could be self made, and thus much more affordable. Of course, in all these self-made situations, the cost in personal labor input is huge, and perhaps outweighs the cost in money! Clay roofs are beautiful and long lasting, but have the same drawbacks as slate in the sense that they require more hefty framing, and are also breakable (should a stray tree limb fall).

Metal roofs are another option. This is the choice we made for the Blue Rocks Home. Although they are certainly not historic in the sense that slate, wood, or clay roofs are, metal roofs are very long lasting (rivaling slate), durable (i.e.: not breakable), and require little or no maintenance. They are also wildly more affordable than the other options listed here, and allow for easy rainwater catchment (for use in irrigation of gardens). Standing seam roofs have less maintenance and longer lives, but are more expensive and require more training in their application than do “architectural” or corrugated metal roofing.

Wall Coverings

The final material to examine in the exploration of the building blocks of the Pennsylvania German home is plaster. Plaster is a mix of many materials including lime dust, hair, or straw mixed together into a substance that hardens much like mortar. The process of plastering walls involved nailing lathe to the studs in the walls and covering the lathe with wet plaster and letting it dry to a hard smooth surface. To the modern person who is used to drywall, we may forget that there was a time when such a material did not exist and walking into any historic home one will note that the walls are plastered.

Although it may involve a little extra work to install, plaster is an important material in our examination of the green qualities of historic buildings. Most modern homes have their walls constructed out of gypsum based drywall. Drywall features an R value of .45 per inch with standard sizes available at home improvement stores being 3/8, ½, and 5/8 of an inch, meaning you never get the full insulating ability of the product. Plaster walls have a comparative R value however, unlike drywall, removed and crumbled plaster, as well as mortar used in pointing stone and brick structures, can be recycled to make fresh material. Drywall once out of its paper shell will crumble to unusable dust.

The use of plaster on walls has gone out of vogue since the advent of drywall and modern stud framing techniques. The value of plaster walls goes beyond the R value and wind-blocking uses of yesterday, however. In contemporary use, clay wall plaster is gaining popularity again.

As a green wall covering, clay plaster is ideal. The obvious reason for this is that it is just what it says it is: clay. all parts of the plaster are 100% natural. using this material instead of paint mean that there are no toxic chemicals being added to your home. Even the most expensive low and no VOC paints have a hard time being 100% natural. Clay also has a naturally occurring anti-microbial property, as well as an ability to “breathe” accepting excess ambient moisture as well as letting it go to maintain a more constant level of moisture in the air. Both of these elements help in the mitigation of mold and mildew issues in the home. Clay wall plaster is not cheap, and it takes some practice to learn the proper application technique, but it is very beautiful, durable,

easily fixable when damaged, and abundant in healthful properties.

Clay paint is another option for wall coverings, offering, to a lesser extant, the benefits of plaster, and also being 100% natural. Clay paint is also very much easier to apply. Its application is almost identical to regular water-based latex paint, though it tends to be substantially thicker.

Layout and Design

To the Pennsylvania Dutch these basic materials provided the foundation of housebuilding. Today we may take a home for granted, being able to turn to any newspaper and then purchase or rent one, but for early Pennsylvania Germans shelter was a matter of creation. Until the early 19th century, except in the most urban areas, many families had to contribute to their own home's construction and to layout these homes they relied on the Old World Germanic culture they had brought with them from Europe. During the earliest settlement years, the Pennsylvania Germans defined themselves by their unique building style based on medieval European aesthetics. These homes featured three rooms, a central chimney, and perhaps most importantly a jamb stove. Examining these homes further will reveal the environmentally friendly aspects present in such a design, aspects that can be kept in mind for furthering the ability for improving one's own home's green elements.

In his book, *Oley Valley Heritage*, Phillip Pendleton gives an extensive history of Pennsylvania German vernacular architecture. He calls the Germanic form that manifested itself in Pennsylvania the Kitchen Entry home. Amos Long also documents this type of home in his book on the Pennsylvania Dutch farm. The most notable feature of these homes was the central chimney of the house that came up through the roof. One entered the house, obviously, into the kitchen of the home, which occupied one entire half of the building and had a cooking fireplace that opened from a central chimney. The other side of the house was usually dived into two rooms: the *Stube* and *Kammer*. The *Kammer* was essentially a master bedroom for the house and the patriarch of the family often utilized the room as his bedroom. The other room was the quintessential room for defining the house as Pennsylvania German. The *Stube* room was a multipurpose room, serving as a parlor, dining room, meeting room, and for accepting visitors. The central feature of the room in the earliest of these homes was a five plate jamb stove, a distinctly Pennsylvania German artifact. The stove was set normally on a stone on the floor and butted to the chimney. In the back of the cooking fireplace was a corresponding set of two holes: one for feeding coals to the stove and the other allowed smoke to escape back to the chimney. The housewife could add coals from the cooking fire through the hole and the heat would then keep the other side of the house warm. These homes appeared in both one story, as in the Bertolet home at the Daniel Boone Homestead in Birdsboro, Pennsylvania, and two story configurations, such as the Henry Antes House in Montgomery County.

This Germanic design is very different from that which many English immigrants used. Pendleton also documents what he deems the Anglo-ethnic vernacular designs of the Hall Parlor and Hall Passage home. In the Hall-Parlor design, the house essentially had two rooms usually arranged side-by-side on the first level, the Hall, or kitchen, and the parlor, which in this case served as a general purpose room, much like the *Stube*, and differed greatly from Victorian parlor. The other style, Hall-Passage, featured a corridor that bounded the other rooms which sometimes contained the staircase if the building was two stories. In this design, the main rooms were often stacked form front to back, when the house was viewed from the front. This design was furthered when the Georgian form of architecture was

transplanted to the colonies during the late 18th century. This style was defined by its aesthetic foundation of balance in architectural features such as doors and windows, and often was built with four rooms bordering a central hall. Key to this discussion is that fact that all three styles of home relied on fireplaces for heat and cooking, with the fireplaces placed on exterior walls of the structure.

This study of vernacular architecture styles, lends many design ideas to the modern builder and remodeler. First is the Germanic reliance on stoves for heating. In the case of a fireplace the majority of the heat escapes out the chimney, and while it might add ambiance to a modern home, a fireplace is still a poor heat source. Historically the reliance on fireplaces meant that in the case of English homes the majority of the heating was occurring on the upper floors of the home. However, the chimneys were also on exterior walls which meant, not only would it take a greater amount of heat to heat the room, a large portion of the potential heat contained within the chimney was escaping outside the house. Further, unlike, modern baseboard heat the stove was central in a room, and a direct source of the heat it gave off. Modern baseboards are wasteful in their reliance upon a boiler to heat water in a cold basement that is then flushed through a pipe that heats metal coils around the outer edges of a room, the water must be heated to a temperature to allow it to maintain enough warmth to provide heat during its travel through the house. Furthering this discussion, in a German home, the chimney was in the center of the house, which meant that the heat escaping up the chimney was radiating out from the center of the entire house, making it able to heat a larger portion of the home. In a time when the majority of homes we live in are heated with base boards or by central air being pushed out of a vent, the efficient design of a central chimney and the increased productivity of a stove of any sort should be something a builder or remodeler can consider during their work.

The Troxell-Steckell home in Egypt, Pennsylvania further demonstrates how popular and important stove heat was historically. The home is essentially a transitional Georgian home, built by middle class German immigrants and features a four room downstairs floor plan and two cooking fireplaces: one either side of the house. However, there is one peculiar aspect of this house. While it is built on an English plan with the expected exterior fireplaces, the Troxell's made sure to place two holes into the sides of the fireplaces to allow the use of jamb stoves in the front rooms of this English style house that was lived in by Germans. This house is not alone in such features and that can be especially appreciated when one walks through the many early 19th century homes built in a more English-American style, such as the Georgian, and notice that many chimneys have holes bored into them for the addition of stove pipes.

In the Blue Rocks Home we used a combination of German and Georgian design, as you can see on the opposing page. We used a variation on the three room floor plan of the kitchen entry home (adding a fourth room-the bathroom). We also used stoves as our primary source of heat. Although we did create two chimneys flanking the house, we positioned those chimneys *inside the walls of the house,* thus recapturing any heat lost to the flue, and also reducing the potential of creosote deposits in the chimney and the risk of fire. The house is very well insulated and easily heated, so we approached heating from a couple different angles: First we put radiant heat lines in the slab floor in the first story. These radiant heat lines are hooked up to a high efficiency gas boiler which is responsible for our hot water heat as well. This is our back up heat. This system will be set at 50 degrees Farenheiht as a back up to the wood stove heat that will be the dominant form of heat for the house. This way we do not have to worry about pipes freezing in the middle of the night or

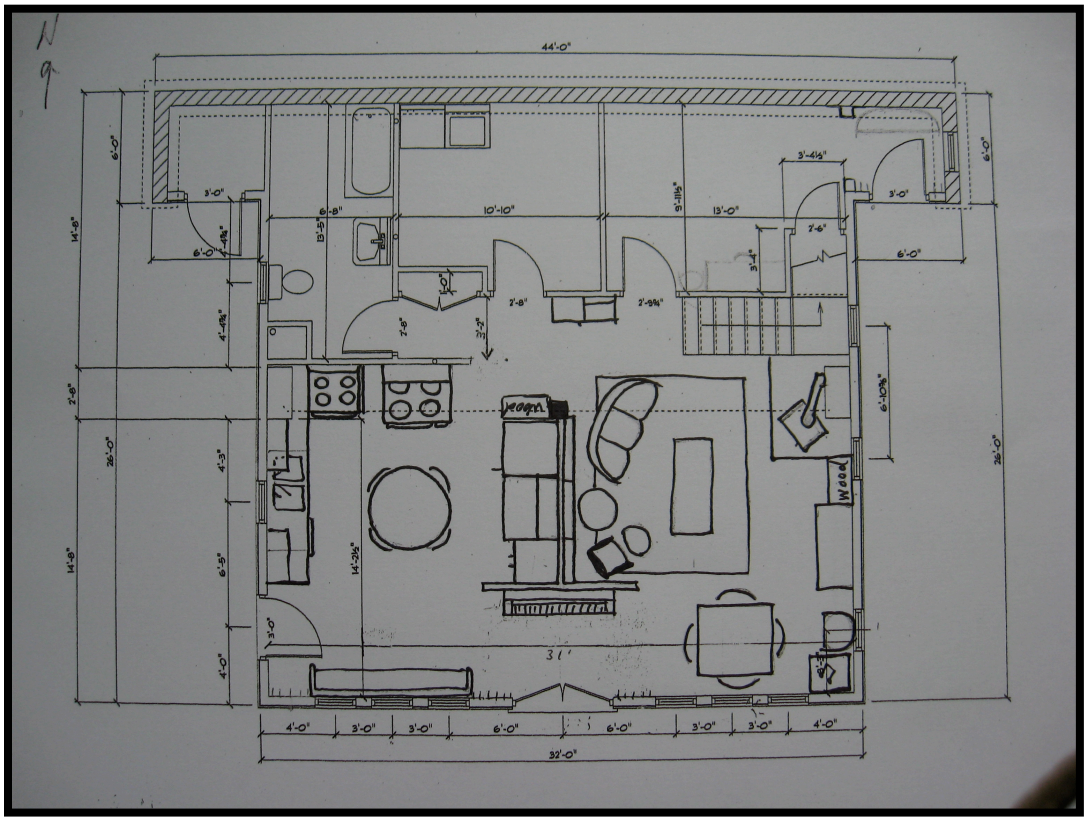
day, and we are free to travel without the need for a house sitter.

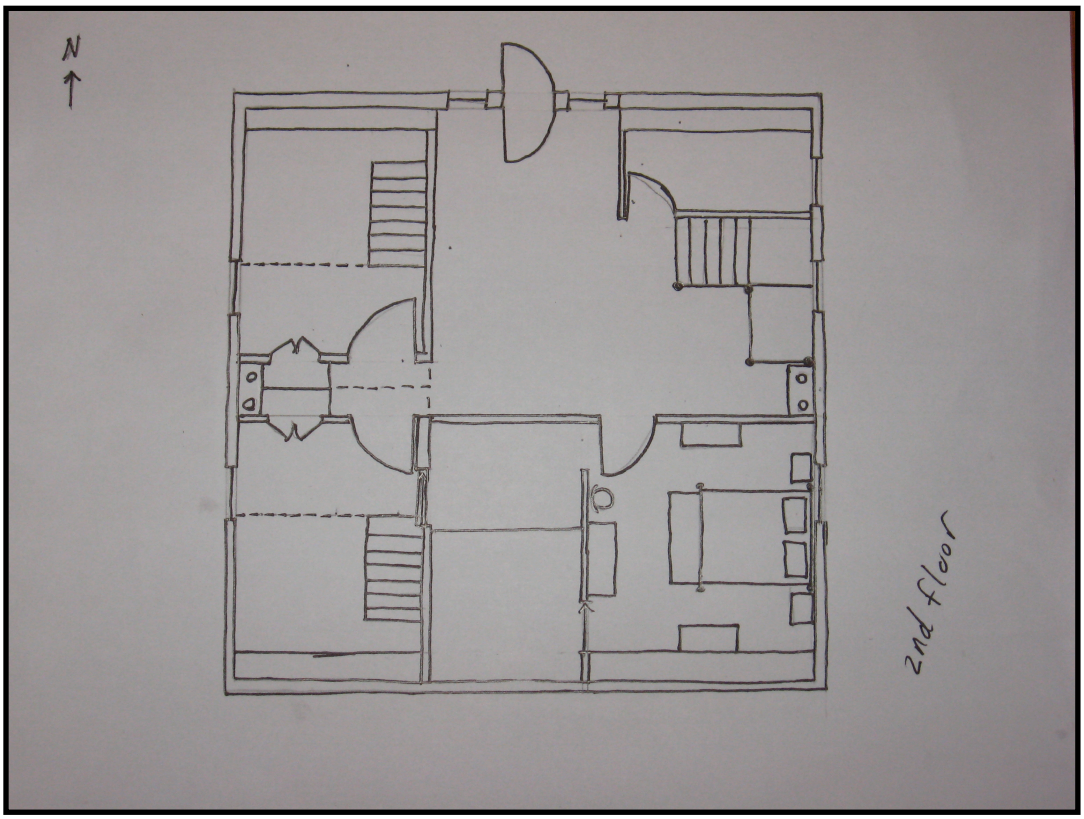
The main source of heat for the house, however is an 1820 Reading Stove works Othello Cookstove. This stove is capable of burning both coal and wood, though we plan to use wood only. This stove serves two purposes. First, it is a cooking surface. During the colder months of the year we plan to cook primarily with this stove, and not with our LP gas stove. By using the wood cook stove for cooking we will also heat the house in an immediate and direct way, saving fossil fuels on two counts! We are quite sure that this stove will fulfill the heating needs for the house for most of the heating season. In that case that there is still some need for warmth we have an additional wood stove (a beautiful Llange red cockelofen stove) for supplemental heat on the coldest days. This second stove is positioned directly next to the staircase of our home, which will allow for the heat to rise to the second story quite easily.

Contemporary politics and preferences reveal a rising interest in energy independence and alternative energies in particular. In the recent years there have been substantial tax credits to those who invest in alternative and green energies, whether in business or in private homes. One easy and traditional way to do this is to incorporate a "biomass stove" into your home. In layman's terms this means a wood, wood pellet, or corn stove.

Stoves are a wonderful source of heat. They provide ambiance and instant gratification. They are immediate, direct heat, they lose nothing in transfer, because there is no transfer. In areas where wood is

Below is a drawing of the floor plan for the Blue Rocks Home. The top of the drawing is the North banked wall. Note the combination of German and Georgian Architectural styles





Above is a drawing of the second story floor plan of the Blue Rocks Home. Note the open staircase and the second story ground level back door (exits to bank).

abundant, they are a very viable, green and inexpensive way to heat a home.

Bank it up!

The unintended very green practices of the Pennsylvania Germans are only further bolstered when one examines their development of the Pennsylvania Bank barn. This barn is common in Pennsylvania and throughout the country wherever Pennsylvania Dutch emigrants have migrated out from the state. The barn is built in two stories and features a forebay, a defining overhang that juts out over the lower level foundation wall, providing shade and shelter from weather for the animals that farmers housed below. However, it is the other defining feature of these barns that is relevant to this discussion: the bank ramp. As its name might suggest, the rear of these barns often placed into a manmade earthen ramp, or hill side. This bank is essential in insulating the barn and can trap warm air in the winter time and cool air in the summer. We have both personally walked into the basement of various bank barns on 90 degree summer days and found the interior of the basement to be well under 70 degrees. Furthermore, before moving to his current home, Zach and his wife lived in an auxiliary home on a still operating farm, built in the 1820's. This home was banked on one side, and as might be expected the banking kept the house cool in the summer to the point where air conditioning was only needed when company was coming to visit and filling up the small space of the home. Jesse found the same to be true in the only mildly banked masonry structure where she and Matthew have been living during the building of their home. The insulating properties represented

by the earthen mass of a banked structure are something that is often overlooked in our modern times.

With this we return to the topic of thermal mass discussed earlier with the masonry materials. The bank barn is the perfect example: the basement of all bank barns is primarily masonry. Sometimes this includes a cement floor and sometimes a dirt one, but the walls are always masonry. The insulating layer of earth is really only more thermal mass, in this case, however, the thermal mass is so enormous that it is unequivocally climate controlling.

When applied in modern construction this mass would be dealt with differently: In the Blue Rocks home we built slab on grade, meaning that there is not basement to our home. The slab has a substantial layer of insulation against heat, moisture, and radiation beneath the poured concrete slab. The back wall of the home, as well as the entire foundation is also solid masonry with substantial insulation on the *exterior*. The solid north wall of the house is banked with earth up to the level of the second story back door. This provides even more thermal mass and its thermal-transfer slowing qualities to our home.

The act of cooling a banked masonry structure in the summer is a bit of an art form. Most people who have no air conditioning open their windows in the summer all day and all night to tempt even the smallest breeze into their homes. In a banked or masonry structure this is folly! As we have learned living in other masonry buildings, the best course of action in summer is to open the windows at night and use fans in the windows to blow cool night air into the house, cooling the building substantially. In the day, as soon as the heat outside the home is higher than inside, the windows should be shut tight, and curtains drawn to retain the cool and reflect out the sun and heat. This pattern repeats itself daily and can become a lovely rhythm to be a part of, particularly when you look at your energy bill!

True to form, the huge thermal mass in the Blue Rocks Home has been doing its job so far as we move into the summer. So long as the windows are open at night and closed during the day, the house is cool and comfortable upstairs and down. The slab and north wall retain the cool of the night air, and allow this coolness to seep out into the house throughout the day.

The main issue to consider in banked and masonry homes is moisture!!! Moisture is the enemy, mold is the consequence! It is vitally important to incorporate adequate water barriers, drainage, and ventilation (in that order). First, prevent humidity in the home during the summer months: make sure that the banked wall and foundation have more than adequate water barriers, do not open the windows at night during rainstorms, when moist air will come into the house, make sure all openings to the outside are adequately sealed. Drainage and ventilation are only used to fix a moisture problem after the moisture has gotten into the house! In old houses it might be necessary to use a dehumidifier to mitigate the problem of mold. It is often cost prohibitive to add moisture barriers to the outside of an old house. Mold is a serious issue, however in these types of houses, and all avenues should be explored in the prevention of mold and mildew!

The Farmstead

The design of the home and barn were not all that made up the farmstead. The farmsteads of the Deitsch were a marvel of self-sufficiency, beauty, and effectiveness. If the Pennsylvania Germans' homes' design and material were not enough to make their vernacular architecture relevant to modern times, their farming practices might. They have left a farming cultural legacy that can be admired by today's hobby or organic farmer. The Pennsylvania Germans who came earliest to Pennsylvania were left to carve out a wilderness and manipulate the land to best lend itself to their personal survival. James Lemon, in his

study of Pennsylvania farming in the colonial era, deems such Pennsylvania German farm practices as extensive instead of intensive. He suggests that the Pennsylvania Germans used what land they had in as many different ways as possible and their understanding of the ecology behind farming allowed the culture to flourish as primarily an agrarian one.

The average Pennsylvania Dutch farm was between 130 and 150 acres in size and on that land they maintained active fields, wood lots, orchards, meadows, and fallow fields. They grew a variety of crops including rye, barley, oats, tobacco, and wheat, as well as produce from a smaller garden. They added to this with orchard fruits such as apples and pears, and wild fruits like strawberries and blackberries. They also kept a variety of animals including horses, sheep, cows, pigs, and chickens. Their crops were rotated based on nutrient absorption from the ground and fields were kept fallow after a full rotation so that they could recover and produce more abundantly when in use. Groups of animals were then allowed to use the fallow land for grazing which not only kept the land from growing too wild, but the natural manure deposits helped return nutrients to the decimated farm land. Essentially the farm was more than just a way to make money. It was a way to survive with nothing else but the farm and the living things contained therein. There was no need for chemical fertilizers, cash crops, or pesticides as the variety of grains, fruits, and animals allowed for the loss of one item to be replaced by another.

The layout of the Deitsch farm centered on efficiency. The buildings, including such structures as the home, barn, root cellar, bake oven, summer kitchen, smokehouse, outhouse, corncrib, spring or well house, etc. were laid out for the sake of ease of use. The buildings used most were closest to the home. Buildings with related uses were built close together. The gardens, fields, orchards, pastures, and woodlots radiated out from the home in just that order: the order of use. The gardens required the most constant tending, and gave the most constant harvest, so they were closest to the home, often just outside the kitchen door. The other elements of the farmstead were laid out with the highest efficiency in mind.

From a first glance this description of traditional farming techniques of the Deitsch could be the introduction page to a textbook on permaculture. In truth, the similarities between traditional Deitsch farming and modern sustainable methods are too numerous to count. Many of the modern methods have the Deitsch to thank for inventing them. In essence, both systems of farming have the same goal: the creation of a harvestable ecosystem which operates with the smallest amount of human input possible.

One need only turn to books such as Rachel Carson's *Silent Spring* or Michael Pollan's *Omnivore's Dilemma* to understand that today's mainstream mechanized farming is not what our ancestor's practiced. Pesticides, cash crops, and the almighty bottom line of industrial farming have replaced the balanced, food based farming of the Pennsylvania Germans. However, for those seeking to take a step for greener and cleaner food sources theirs is a system of which to aspire. What the extensive versus intensive practices give us, is an understanding for care of the land, not a need to overbear it with pesticides and chemicals. Understanding crop rotation and the benefits of grazing animals on fallow land eliminates the need to saturate the ground with artificial and chemical based fertilizers.

The Pennsylvania German farming system stands as an example of what any organic farmer can emulate, despite the seeming short comings caused by vague government standards and lax enforcement in organic farming today,

something of which Pollan also reminds us. Perhaps with the spurt in popularity of Community Supported Agriculture programs and hobby farms across the country, we will once again see a rebirth of such careful, environmentally friendly agriculture.

The use of such environmentally conscious practices in farming, may be the way of the future, or as the Pennsylvania Germans can show, the way of the past. The Pennsylvania Dutch immigrants that came to America in the 18th century had few things on their mind but survival and a fresh start after fleeing poverty and serfdom in Europe. In the time since Pennsylvania Germans first established a vernacular architecture, the world has certainly transformed. However, with this examination of Deitsch vernacular design and practice has demonstrated; many of the "advancements" of our contemporary lives leave more than a little to be desired.

Today, many people are beginning to abide by more greener and environmentally friendly ways of living. One need only walk into any major supermarket to see how much this movement as taken hold our society. To those seeking a way to "green up" their life, the Pennsylvania Dutch example is one that anyone can proudly imitate. From the initial genius of design and layout, to the positive differences in R factor insulation of many of the vernacular architecture features, and the conscious, sustainable farming practices of an extensive versus intensive type farming; the Pennsylvania Germans have many positive environmentally friendly aspects to offer to us in the present. For anyone looking to follow a greener path to the future, one cannot go wrong by looking back to the Pennsylvania Germans.

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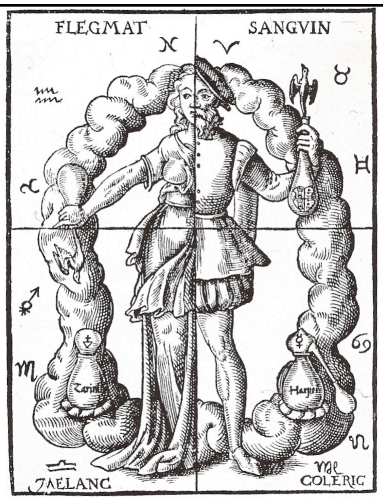
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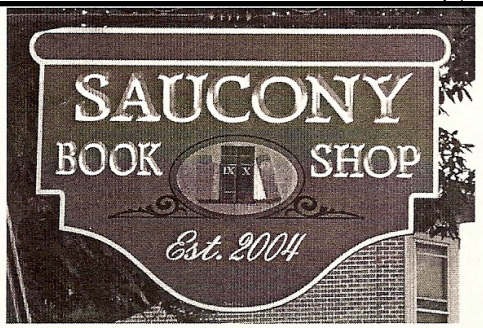
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